# ArchiMate cheat sheet — every element, by layer and aspect

All 60 elements of ArchiMate® 3.2 in one grid, placed by the two questions that decide where an element belongs.

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## THE FRAMEWORK

layer answers **whom it serves** · aspect answers **what kind of thing it is**

| | ACTIVE STRUCTURE<br>who or what does it | BEHAVIOUR<br>what is done | PASSIVE STRUCTURE<br>what it is done to |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Motivation**<br>why — its own aspect | Stakeholder · Driver · Assessment · Goal · Outcome · Principle · Requirement · Constraint · Meaning · Value | | |
| **Strategy**<br>what we must be able to do | Resource | Capability · Value Stream · Course of Action | — |
| **Business**<br>what the organisation does for its customers | Business Actor · Business Role · Business Collaboration · Business Interface | Business Process · Business Function · Business Interaction · Business Event · Business Service | Business Object · Contract · Representation · **Product †** |
| **Application**<br>what software does for the business | Application Component · Application Collaboration · Application Interface | Application Function · Application Interaction · Application Process · Application Event · Application Service | Data Object |
| **Technology**<br>what infrastructure does for software | Node · Device · System Software · Technology Collaboration · Technology Interface · Path · Communication Network | Technology Function · Technology Process · Technology Interaction · Technology Event · Technology Service | Artifact |
| **Physical**<br>part of Technology, not a layer of its own | Equipment · Facility · Distribution Network | *— uses Technology behaviour* | Material |
| **Implementation & Migration**<br>how we get there | — | Work Package · Implementation Event | Deliverable · **Plateau ‡** · **Gap ‡** |
| **Composite**<br>no layer of their own | Grouping — anything that belongs together · Location — where elements sit or behaviour happens | | |

**† Product is composite**, not passive structure: it aggregates services and passive elements across layers, under a contract. Most cheat sheets file it wrongly. **‡ Plateau** aggregates core elements as they stand at one point in time; **Gap** states the difference between two plateaus.

## RELATIONSHIPS

11 + junction

### STRUCTURAL — STATIC COHERENCE

- **Composition** — the part cannot exist without the whole
- **Aggregation** — groups parts that can exist alone
- **Assignment** — who performs it, where it runs
- **Realization** — the concrete one delivers the abstract one

### DEPENDENCY — ONE NEEDS ANOTHER

- **Serving** — provides its functionality to another
- **Access** — reads, writes or deletes a passive element
- +/- **Influence** — affects a motivation element, for or against
- **Association** — a link the language has no word for

### DYNAMIC — SOMETHING MOVES

- **Triggering** — this then that — order in time
- **Flow** — something is transferred — data, money, goods

### OTHER & CONNECTOR

- **Specialization** — is a particular kind of
- **Junction** — and / or — joins relationships of one type

**The derivation rule — the one worth memorising**

A chain of relationships pointing the same way can be replaced by **the weakest link in the chain**. That is how a diagram stays readable when you zoom out.

`composition › aggregation › assignment › realization › serving › access › influence › association`

### THREE PAIRS THAT GET CONFUSED

**Assignment vs realization.** Assignment allocates a performer — an actor *does* a process. Realization says something concrete delivers something abstract — a process *provides* a service.

**Serving vs flow.** Serving is a standing offer: it is available to you. Flow is one actual transfer during one run.

**Composition vs aggregation.** A composed part dies with its whole and has exactly one whole. An aggregated part survives on its own and may belong to several.

## PLACING AN ELEMENT — TWO QUESTIONS

**1. Whom does it serve?** That is the layer. Technology serves applications, applications serve the business, the business serves its customers. **2. What kind of thing is it?** Active structure does something, behaviour is what is done, passive structure is what it is done to.

## INTERNAL OR EXTERNAL — THE PAIR PEOPLE MISS

Every layer repeats the same pair. A **Service** is the outward face of **behaviour** — what others may use. An **Interface** is the outward face of **active structure** — where they reach it. Everything else in the layer is internal, and no one outside should depend on it.

## READING THE NOTATION

**Colour is convention, not specification** — yellow business, blue application, green technology, purple motivation, tan strategy, pink implementation. The small **icon in the top-right** corner of a box carries the actual element type; a rounded box is behaviour, a square one is structure.

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Element set per the ArchiMate® 3.2 Specification. ArchiMate is a registered trademark of The Open Group.

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